

SCENE 1

ARBITER LIBRARY

1. "CHECK IN"

It is the near distant future, but everything is pretty backwards in the small town of Arbiter in the nation's heartland. The end of 2040 celebration aisle is the indicator of what time period it is. Arbiter Library is preparing to close up for the day. There is but one trusty librarian named DEZ keeping it open. DEZ is waiting for the incoming library fellow. They speak to the collections on the shelves in the meantime.

DEZ

JUST CHECKING IN...

The collections come to life and initially speak through the sounds of the orchestra.

DEZ (CONT'D)

I know, I know. The new fellow is late. Yes, yes. They are our only applicant this year. These past few years. We just have to make of what we have. Isn't that why you are still here, on this shelf? Rare things, like...

DEWEY enters, looking at their phone as though they were mapping.

DEWEY

MAY I CHECK IN?

The collections start to be understandable.

COLLECTIONS

CHECK OUT THE NEWCOMER!

DEWEY

Who's talking?

DEZ

The books. It's always the books.

DEWEY

The books?

DEZ

Who else gives off words besides our own mouths?

DEWEY

Who?

DEZ

You act as though you've never seen a book in your life.

DEWEY

Twenty years ain't that long.

DEZ

You're kidding...?

DEWEY

I'm Dewey.

DEZ

Dewey. The first thing I ask of you to do is to hold this book.

DEZ hands a book to DEWEY.

DEWEY

So this is what it feels like.

COLLECTIONS

To have responsibilities?

DEWEY

Stop talking, inside voices! No. To hold a book...

DEZ

That's what this fellowship is for. We put a book on hold the old fashion way.

DEWEY

I thought this is how a book is always supposed to be held. At least, that's what my grandparents' photos showed.

DEZ

They showed you how to use the slip inside to place books on hold?

DEWEY

Not that hold. This hold.

DEWEY holds up the book.

COLLECTIONS

LET'S CHECK IN ON THE FELLAS.

DEZ

You're saying that you've never touched a book before...?

DEZ reviews DEWEY's portfolio.

DEWEY

I'll say that I've always wanted to.

DEZ

What kind of city is the 451 area code?

DEWEY

It's actually 415. San Francisco.

DEZ

Does San Francisco not have books where you come from?

DEWEY

Everything is automated there now.

DEZ

You should have applied elsewhere. You'd automatically fit in.

DEWEY

Your library is non-competitive. I do wish that Arbiter is by the harbor, but this town is in the middle of nowhere!

DEZ

That's the heartland for ya!

DEWEY

Ugh. I could've been with my college friends, interning in New York City or Seattle.

DEZ

But would their collections speak to you?

DEWEY

I bet they would speak more to me, then these piles of dust.

COLLECTIONS

Who you calling piles of dust?!

DEWEY

Sorry, what?

COLLECTIONS

It's not you. Thanks for being honest. Dez, have you given us our sponge baths?

DEZ

It's hard to do that considering you'd be watered down.

[It becomes apparent that Dewey has not seen a physical book in their life as they have been thriving in a tech-heavy society. However, Dewey is open to learning paperback in honor of their grandparents and with the encouragement of the talking collections.]

DEZ takes the book from DEWEY.

End of "CHECK IN"

TONI SEXTON, the newly instated board member, barges in.

TONI

Boarding up for the day?

DEZ

Yes, Toni.

TONI

How'd you like to stop boarding up for the day and instead make this library 24 7?

DEZ

I have 24 reasons to doubt your sincerity and 7 reasons to bluff it. The city council has cut funding, remember?

TONI

You'll remember who saved this library.

DEZ

Not really if you keep leaving town.

TONI

I am not leaving any time soon. I got what I needed from the startup tech giants. And who's this shrimp?

DEZ

Dewey. This year's fellow.

DEWEY

And who is this *giant* supposed to be?

TONI

Click the X on your phone to find out.

DEWEY

Which one?

TONI

Any and all. Then click "about."

DEWEY opens an app on their phone.

2. "UNDER MY WING"

DEZ

I was just about to take Dewey under my wing.

TONI

Would you like to do it...
UNDER MY WING?

DEZ

Your wing?

TONI

The Toni Sexton Wing!

DEWEY

Toni Sexton... The founder of X-Tech?

DEWEY finds TONI's company
portrait on their phone.

DEZ

The most extra tech I've seen in my lifetime.

TONI

You're being extra, geezer. The board has
approved my acquisition of this unnamed wing.

DEWEY

We were just talking to its collections?

TONI

Talking to the collections...? So, it's not
just Dez who has voices inside their heads.

DEWEY

Doesn't everybody have a voice inside?

TONI

Not a single voice of reason. The tech speaks
reasons for me!

TONI pushes aside the collections
on a shelf. They musically scream
in terror. TONI places a single
tablet on the shelf.

TONI (CONT'D)

Why should these take up space - real estate
space?

[Toni sings about how they are saving the library by buying

out a wing and having it named by them. The underlying motive is that Toni had their Arbiter Library card suspended when they were a kid because they wrote their name on everything.]

End of "UNDER MY WING"

DEZ

This is not the library I grew up in.

TONI

This is the library I always wanted to grow up in.

DEZ

You'll never grow up.

TONI

If you had let me be a kid, I would have.

DEZ

You were no kid. You have always been a monster. Writing your name on everything was the worst experience I had here.

TONI

Boo hoo. You had to do such menial tasks when you were a fellow.

DEZ

Permanent markers made cleaning more professional.

TONI

It was unprofessional of you to suspend my library card.

DEZ

It's been a few decades. Move on.

DEZ exits.

TONI

And this will be your last year... Time to make my move.

TONI goes to DEWEY, who is currently organizing books.

SCENE 2

SEXTON WING

3. "E IS EVERYTHING"

DEWEY

I admire what you do, Toni.

TONI

I do nothing. The tech does everything.

DEWEY

E IS EVERYTHING.

TONI

E?

DEWEY

Electronics.

TONI

A book can hold a thousand pages. A thousand electrons can hold a thousand books. And it yet weighs a thousand times less.

[It becomes evident that Toni is a union-busting, harassing, and assaulting boss at their work in X-Tech. It conflicts with Dewey's social progressiveness but technological interests.]

End of "E IS EVERYTHING"

TONI hands an electronic card to
DEWEY.

TONI

This is the library's fund. Spend wisely... on everything!

DEWEY

Why this power?

TONI

It's the closest power you'll have to me. I have one more thing to *replace- Remove* from this library.

DEWEY

And what's that?

TONI

The old guard.

DEWEY

Dez?

TONI

They'll be patrolling another week. I meet the board this weekend for the vote. Now, spend to the ground as you please!

TONI leaves.

SCENE 3

ARBITER LIBRARY

DEZ enters.

[A conversation unfolds that Dez's time here is short.]

4. "BORROWED TIME"

DEZ

There is one thing no one can ever borrow.

DEWEY

And what's that?

DEZ

Time.

[This duet between Dez and Dewey is about how things have changed societally and it won't adapt to people set in their traditional ways.]

End of "BORROWED TIME"

DEWEY pulls out the library's
money card.

DEZ (CONT'D)

Wait? Even I don't have access to the library's
funds.

DEWEY

Toni passed this onto me.

DEZ

I'm guessing they assume that you'd spend
everything into the ground like your generation
constantly does.

DEWEY

It's time to continue the cycle!

DEWEY gets a tablet.

DEZ

No!

DEWEY

Relax. I'm purchasing publications.

DEZ

Of what? We're in a library... *with e-books!*

DEWEY

I'm publishing...

DEZ

What?

DEWEY

If Toni wants names on books, they are getting names on books. I love vanity press!

TONI

Did someone say vanity?

DEZ

Unsex my wing at once!

TONI

Or what?

DEWEY

Face the sexless public!

DEWEY displays bad news for TONI from a tablet.

TONI

My name on a book? Aww... You shouldn't have!

(Reading)

"Toni Sexton's Crime Incorporated... X Out Sexton... A Stark Reminder of Toni..."

What are these?!

DEZ

Your legacy.

DEWEY

Words I never thought I'd say: let's check on the news!

TONI

(Reading)

"Toni Sexton's scandals... Sexton busts unions... The overspender... Toni Sexton of crime... The public calls Toni Sexton to step down from the board of Arbiter Library."

DEZ

But first, step up and take down your name.

DEWEY swats TONI's hand aside.

DEZ (CONT'D)

Your library money card is suspended.

TONI

Not again!

DEZ

Quit writing your name on this library and it wouldn't be a problem!

TONI

In the name of X-Tech, I am also removing all electronics and e-books from Arbiter Library!

DEWEY

(Reluctantly)

This is the future!

DEZ

I'll always be present for you. You'll make it through this fellowship.

TONI

Fellows. It is time for me to set sail. This is not the last you'll see my name!

TONI departs.

DEZ

Certainly, this will be the last time we mention their name.

SCENE 4

UNSEXTON WING

The COLLECTIONS return and replaces the electronic tablets.

5. "CHECK OUT"

[Everything goes back to the way things were before e-books took over. The library's collections are at peace. We can check out in comfort, knowing that Dewey experiences their first paper book.]

DEWEY scans their first book ever.

End of "CHECK OUT"

CHECKED OUT